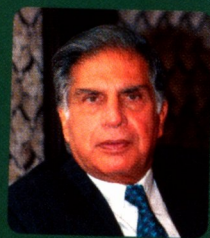




THE TATAS The Cairn

J.R.D. Tata rented the two-storey Scottish-style bungalow set in a one-acre plot, but it fell into disuse after his death. It was purchased by the Tatas for Rs 50 crore nearly a decade ago. New residence was built for group chairman but Ratan Tata has no plans of moving in.



back Kumar Mangalam moved into his mansion. The yet-to-be-named home with high wooden gates features a rooftop swimming pool, manicured lawns with fountains, a 20-seat private theatre and large pointed arches. Residents whisper the reason for its unusually deep foundations which cut into the solid rock of Cumballa Hill: the Birlas have built a bunker a level under their underground car park. This accessory conjures up visions of dystopia—of families retreating into their personal vault in the event of a flood, earthquake or nuclear attack, snacking on tinned food and waiting for relief. But the biggest disaster, say conservation architects, lurks in unplanned urban sprawl. The casual observer would be hard-pressed to locate either Malabar or Cumballa Hill. The undulating road is the only trace of its geography. Slums have crept up the ridge from where JRD often looked out at the city and art deco bungalows are obscured by Manhattans.

"It is an example of unplanned development where the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) allows buildings to come up where they don't have the required infrastructure," says Milind Deora, MP, south Mumbai.

Architects like Hafeez Contractor say this is happening because space in the city is at a premium and the rich

have fewer places to go to. "If Mukesh Ambani was in the US, he would have lived on an exclusive ranch spread over a few hundred acres. In Mumbai, there's no space so he has no option but to go skywards. I think it is efficient use of space," says Contractor. For him, it will be a homecoming of sorts. Dhirubhai Ambani's joint family lived in a flat in Mumbai's first skyscraper, the 24-storey Usha Kiran on Carmichael Road. It was built in the mid-1970s and the family lived here for over a decade before moving out into Sea Wind, their own 14-storey skyscraper at Cuffe Parade. The city was abuzz with the five-storey drive-in car park crowned by a swimming pool and separate floors for the family (the brothers still live here). Now, Mukesh's 490-ft tower, promises to do the same.

The plot on which the Petit bungalow stood was converted into an orphanage in the last century. Work on the site, which began three years ago, is already behind schedule owing to legal hassles over its ownership. The plot was purchased by Reliance from the Waqf Board in 2002 for Rs 21 crore. Mukesh can be spotted on Sundays supervising work on the structure which is reportedly going to be a Diwali gift for his wife this year.

Placed atop Cumballa Hill which is

roughly 700 ft above sea level, it assumes the proportion of a 60-storey structure like the twin towers being built by Shapoorji Pallonji at Tardeo. A staff of nearly 600 will service the building meant for six people—Ambani matriarch Kokilaben, Mukesh, Neeta and their three children. A helipad on the rooftop with its own control tower means India's first family chopper out to the airport and the Reliance fleet of six private jets. Designed by Chicago-based skyscraper architects Perkins+Will in 2004, the tower features several garden levels and hydroponically-grown plants that weave in and out of the building to demarcate different levels—like separating the corporate meeting facility and parking levels from the residential space.

A Rs 5.5 crore beautification project for the road is still stuck pending approval from BMC for the past two years. A water shortage means that the nearly 1,000 families in the 53 buildings on Altamount Road now fork out Rs 1,000 per month for, horror of horrors, tanker water. The residents of Usha Kiran, Mumbai's original skyscraper, pay Rs 1.5 lakh a month for the, "dirty and horrible" as a resident puts it, tanker water. "We are a part of the city and are affected by all its problems," says Captain Batra, chairman of the Altamount Road Area Citizens Committee.

Cars have begun spilling out of buildings and onto both sides of the narrow road. Clearly power, water and parking space are problems Antilia—with parking for 200 cars, its own sub-station and water reserve—will not face. Residents bemoan the apathy of the authorities and the lack of town planning which allows huge buildings to come up on narrow roads. "I am not against high-rises, but how can you have them here with such narrow roads and no infrastructure?" asks Rajesh Jhaveri, chairman of the Carmichael Road Citizens' Committee, which stalled construction on the twin towers citing the excavation of 1,50,000 tonne of rubble from the hillside. They are determined to stop other towers from coming up. Surely, if more properties are thinking of going vertical here, they may have a fight on their hands. ■